

Section 15 – Visual Forbidden List

STATUS: APPROVED

Purpose

This section protects the CLA identity by clearly defining what is not allowed.

The Visual Forbidden List exists to preserve:

- * Excellence
- * Consistency
- * Accessibility
- * Authenticity
- * Performance
- * Long-term quality
- * The mission of the church

These rules apply regardless of future contributors, technologies, or design trends.

Exceptions should be extremely rare and require explicit approval from the Project Owner.

Design Philosophy

The CLA Brand & Design Language defines what the website should become.

The Visual Forbidden List defines what the website must never become.

Together they protect the integrity of the CLA identity.

Visual Clutter

The CLA website must never include:

- * Overcrowded layouts
- * Too many competing buttons
- * Too many competing CTAs
- * Excessive colors competing for attention
- * Too many different card styles on one page
- * Decorative elements without purpose
- * Visual noise
- * Layouts that confuse visitors

Guiding Principle

Every page should feel calm, intentional, and understandable within a few seconds.

Typography Violations

The website should never introduce random typography that weakens the Design Language.

Approved Rule

The Project Owner may introduce new fonts whenever they provide a meaningful improvement.

Every new font should be evaluated for:

- * Readability
- * Accessibility
- * Elegance
- * Long-term usability
- * Consistency with the CLA identity

Once approved, the font becomes part of the official Design Language and should be documented in this OS.

Contributors should never independently introduce new typography systems.

Guiding Principle

Typography should evolve intentionally—not randomly.

Photography Standards

The website should never intentionally publish poor-quality photography when a better alternative exists.

Approved Rule

High-quality photography is always the goal.

However:

Authentic ministry moments are more important than technical perfection.

If an important event is documented with imperfect photography, it may still be published when it faithfully represents the story.

Whenever possible, photographs should be:

- * Properly exposed
- * Sharp
- * Well composed
- * Professionally edited

Minor imperfections are acceptable when they preserve meaningful ministry moments.

Guiding Principle

A real ministry moment is often more valuable than a technically perfect photograph.

Media Playback

The CLA website should never use media in a way that distracts or frustrates visitors.

Approved Rule

Auto-playing media is permitted when it genuinely enhances the experience.

Examples include:

- * Hero background videos
- * Conference highlights
- * Worship atmosphere
- * Seasonal experiences

Whenever auto-play is used:

- * Videos begin muted
- * Audio never starts unexpectedly
- * Motion remains subtle
- * Performance remains excellent
- * Accessibility is respected
- * Visitors retain playback control whenever appropriate

Guiding Principle

Media should create atmosphere—not distraction.

Component Consistency

The CLA website should never contain inconsistent component systems.

Every:

- * Button
- * Card
- * Form
- * Navigation
- * Gallery
- * Badge
- * Dialog
- * Interactive component

should follow the official CLA Component Library.

Shared standards include:

- * Typography
- * Radius
- * Shadows
- * Spacing
- * Motion
- * Color usage
- * Interaction behavior

Future Evolution

Every six months the Project Owner will review the component library.

Components may be:

- * Improved
- * Simplified
- * Expanded
- * Replaced
- * Retired

Once approved, new components become the new standard.

Guiding Principle

Consistency today. Thoughtful evolution tomorrow.

Accessibility Balance

Accessibility is an important design objective.

Whenever possible:

- * Accessibility
- * Beauty
- * Performance
- * User Experience

should work together.

When a genuine design tradeoff exists:

The Project Owner may determine the most appropriate balance.

Such decisions should:

- * Be intentional
- * Be documented

- * Be reviewed during the next six-month Design Review

Accessibility should never be sacrificed simply for decoration or temporary trends.

Guiding Principle

Accessibility should guide great design—not prevent thoughtful design decisions.

Publishing Standards

The CLA website should never publish:

- * Placeholder pages
- * Incomplete pages
- * Half-finished content
- * “Coming Soon” pages intended for public viewing

Every public page should meet the CLA quality standard before publication.

Internal drafts should remain private until complete.

Guiding Principle

Every published page represents the CLA brand.

Pop-ups & Interruptions

The website should not interrupt visitors immediately after arrival.

Visitors should first experience the website naturally.

Preferred alternatives include:

- * Homepage feature sections
- * Announcement banners
- * Event highlights
- * Ministry cards
- * Contextual CTAs

Future Review

During each six-month Design Review the Project Owner may reconsider pop-ups if they genuinely improve the visitor experience.

Any approved change should be documented before becoming part of the Design Language.

Guiding Principle

Invite people into the experience—don’t interrupt them before it begins.

Marketing & Promotions

The CLA website should never prioritize marketing over ministry.

The website exists to:

- * Share the Gospel
- * Help people connect with Jesus
- * Welcome visitors
- * Serve the church

The website should never use:

- * Aggressive sales tactics
- * Clickbait
- * Misleading messaging
- * Fake urgency
- * Manipulative countdowns
- * Excessive donation prompts
- * Pressure-based pop-ups
- * Advertising that distracts from ministry

Appropriate promotion includes:

- * Events
- * Ministries
- * Testimonies
- * Opportunities to serve
- * Giving
- * Community involvement

Guiding Principle

Ministry always comes before marketing.

Delight & Innovation

The CLA website should never avoid creativity simply because it is not strictly functional.

Beautiful experiences help communicate excellence.

Features may exist because they are:

- * Inspiring
- * Beautiful
- * Delightful
- * Memorable
- * Emotionally engaging

Every feature should still:

- * Respect the CLA Design Language
- * Preserve performance
- * Respect accessibility whenever practical
- * Improve the visitor experience

Guiding Principle

Great design is not only useful—it is memorable.

Authenticity & Truthfulness

The website should never knowingly present false information as fact.

The website should never use:

- * Fake testimonials
- * Fabricated statistics
- * Invented ministry stories
- * False event information
- * Misleading claims
- * AI-generated content presented as factual without verification

Privacy Exceptions

To protect individuals, the Project Owner may intentionally:

- * Change names
- * Remove identifying information
- * Generalize locations
- * Protect personal details
- * Anonymize testimonies

These changes exist to protect privacy—not to deceive.

Whenever possible:

- * Obtain permission before publishing identifiable stories.
- * Respect requests for anonymity.
- * Protect children and vulnerable individuals.
- * Follow legal and ethical privacy standards.

Guiding Principle

Truth should always be communicated with wisdom, integrity, and respect.

Inspiration & Industry Best Practices

The CLA website should actively learn from exceptional digital experiences.

The Project Owner is encouraged to study outstanding work from:

- * Churches
- * Apple
- * Stripe
- * Linear
- * Airbnb
- * Notion
- * Framer
- * Award-winning designers
- * Modern UI leaders

The goal is to learn:

- * UX
- * Navigation
- * Layout
- * Storytelling
- * Accessibility
- * Motion
- * Photography
- * Content presentation

Ideas may be adopted and refined when they strengthen the CLA website.

Every adopted idea should:

- * Fit naturally within the CLA Design Language.
- * Support the church's mission.
- * Respect intellectual property.
- * Become uniquely CLA.

Guiding Principle

Great designers learn from everyone—but build something uniquely their own.

Performance First

The CLA website should never sacrifice performance without meaningful reason.

Every feature should be evaluated for:

- * Loading speed
- * Responsiveness
- * Accessibility
- * Mobile experience
- * Overall user experience

Large animations, heavy scripts, oversized media, and unnecessary visual effects should not noticeably reduce performance.

Six-Month Review

Every six months the Project Owner should evaluate:

- * New technologies
- * Performance improvements
- * Modern browser capabilities
- * Better implementation methods

If a better balance between performance and experience exists, the Design Language may evolve.

Guiding Principle

Performance is a feature.

Final Vision

The purpose of this Design Language is not simply to create beautiful pages.

Its purpose is to create a shared way of thinking that guides the CLA website for many years.

Future designers, developers, ministry leaders, and contributors should understand:

- * The mission
- * The philosophy
- * The Design Language
- * Governance
- * Evolution
- * Components
- * Accessibility
- * Motion
- * Photography
- * User Experience
- * Decision making

without guessing.

Living Legacy

The CLA Brand & Design Language OS exists to preserve:

- * Excellence
- * Consistency
- * Innovation
- * Authenticity

- * Craftsmanship
 - * Ministry
 - * User Experience
 - * The unique identity of CLA
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Final Guiding Principle

People should recognize CLA because of its consistency, craftsmanship, authenticity, and heart for people—not because of a particular designer, trend, or technology.

Final Statement

The CLA Brand & Design Language OS exists so that every future decision strengthens the mission, the ministry, and the identity of CLA.

It is a living system that evolves intentionally while remaining faithful to Jesus Christ, the church, and the people it serves.